MCP

Title:
The Main Character

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CHARACTERS

Grace

Patty

Teacher

Student 1

Student 2

Student 3

Little Sally

Young Grace

Becky Simmons

(Grace starts front waving over her shoulder. Patty character starts at her back for sound effect purposes. Patty yells “WATCH OUT” and Grace screams. Patty makes crashing and brake squealing sound effects.)

Patty
Are you okay?

Grace
I think so.

Patty
You crossed the middle of the street and almost got hit by that bus!

Grace
It swerved just in time.

Patty
Luckily all those cars were in the oncoming traffic lane to slow it down.

Grace
Phew.

Patty
You know what this means, right?

Grace
What?

Patty

You are the main character!

Grace
What now?

Patty
The main character!

Grace
The what?

Patty
The main character!

Grace
The wha-

Patty
The main character!

Grace
I am completely lost here.

TRANSITION

Patty is now the teacher, and Grace the students

Teacher
Please be seated. Posture please. No slouching. That's still slouching. Still slouching. Still. Sit up. Sit. Right. Up. There you, oh, right back down again. Okay. (Clears throat) Today's lecture is on The Main Character.

In any good story there are FIVE types of characters. But today we will focus on….yes, we have a question already?

Student 1
May I go to the bathroom?

Teacher
No.

Student 1
What if I stop by the vending machines on my way back and bring you some flaming hot cheetos?

Teacher
And a Diet Coke?

Student 1
Done.

Teacher
Done. Alright. Now, there are five basic characters, but we are going to focus on...

Student 2
Five characters according to who?

Teacher
Whom. And Joseph Campbell. Well, at least what I remember from when I read him back in college.

Student 2
Didn’t he write a Hero with a Thousand Faces?

Teacher
He did.

Student 2
So, doesn’t that mean there are a thousand types of characters?

Teacher
Shut it.

Student 3
You can’t say that.

Teacher
I can because you are not the main character. You are a minor character.

Student 2
How do you know you aren’t a minor character?

Teacher
Focus! You know you have a main character when they 1) have a compelling backstory that drives who they are, usually tragic, 2) have a loyal sidekick, 3) cannot be gravely injured physically or emotionally no matter what happens, and 4) things usually work out for them.

Grace
Like when I walk in front of a bus and it swerves and hits oncoming traffic instead?

Teacher
Exactly. You are the main character.

Student 3
What about a minor character?

Teacher
Oh, you for sure can be injured or die. Sometimes that’s the only purpose of your character.

Student 3

What?
Teacher
Watch the first five minutes of any action movie.

Grace
But me?

Teacher
You could jump out of a fourth floor window into some fire escapes and fall to the ground, you will have minor cuts and bruises and immediately jump and walk away with a slight limp that will disappear in a minute or so.

Student 3
What would happen if I jumped out of a fourth floor window?

Teacher
You would spend the rest of the story in traction in the hospital.

Student 3
What?

Teacher
At best the main character would visit you after her story is over to share one callback joke to sort of wrap up the story. Turning your tragic accident and long physical therapy journey into a throwaway joke because the main character is the most important character.

Grace
And I’m the main character.

Patty
And that must make me the sidekick!

Grace

I’m sure you are a main character.

Patty
My name is Patty, that’s not a main character name. And I’m on the chess team. Sidekick.

Grace
Well, don’t main characters have an arch nemesis? I don’t have an arch nemesis.

Teacher
They do.

Grace
The closest I can think of is Becky Simmons, but that was back in third grade.

Teacher
Oh no!

Grace
What?

Teacher
You are the main character and you referenced an incident from your past. You know what that means?!

Grace
What?

Patty
Flashback!

FLASHBACK TRANSITION

Grace
It’s lunchtime!

Patty
I can see that! Look! There you are!

Grace
Oh no, it’s bartering time.

Patty
Bartering?

Grace
Becky Simmons was a master barter-er-er-er (pause) er

Patty
We get it.

Grace
She would have these very intricate trades, and she would always end up on the better end of the deal.

Patty
What would she get?

Grace
Peaches, Pez, Goldfish, Goldfish Pretzel, Goldfish colors, Goldfish whole wheat, Goldfish pizza, Goldfish Parmesan.

Patty
Wait, there’s a Goldfish Parmesan?

Grace
Yes, they are delicious.

Becky
Okay everyone, it's barter time. Hello little Sally.

Sally
Hi Becky Simmons.

Patty
You used to be called Sally?

Grace
No, that's not me, I'm using this as an example for how mean Becky was.

Patty
Got it.

Grace
No problem. Now let's get back to the story.

Patty and Grace
Flashback

Grace
I forgot where I was.

Patty
You were….I forgot as well.

Grace
Let's just take a moment, it will come to us.

Long Pause

Patty
It looks like someone is taking notes over there, maybe they know where you were.

Grace
I remember.

Becky
Hello Little Sally, would you like to …..trade? (Evil laugh)

Sally
That was quite the evil laugh.

Becky
It’s not an evil laugh, that’s just how I laugh, it’s genetics, I can’t change genetics.

Sally
Okay, I’ll trust you. That seems like not a bad idea at all to do so. Trusting. That is.

Becky
Give me your apple slices.

Sally
Here you go.

Becky
These are Fuji apple slices?!

Sally
I know, they are my favorite.

Becky

Haven’t you checked the apple market recently? Fuji apples aren’t THE apple anymore. Their stock is down.

Sally
What? My mother bought them just last night and she paid a ton for them.

Becky
Your mother was robbed. Sure, last week, for these slices, I could get you two, maybe even three packs of Goldfish crackers, but today? You’d be lucky to get two, maybe three actual goldfish crackers.

Sally
Really?

Becky
And I am talking cheddar, not the good ones, like pizza or parmesan.

Sally
Cheddar are my favorite.

Becky
I can get you four goldfish crackers for those apple slices then.

Sally
Oh, ummm

Becky
Now if you had granny smith apples.

Sally
But I don’t like granny smith apples.

Becky
No one does, but they make for great pies, and apple pies are big right now., Big!

Sally
Apple pies are back in? I thought blueberry pies were in?

Becky
Blueberry? What are they teaching you in second grade? This education system is broken.

Sally
I know my colors.

Becky
Because I like you and you are still learning, I'll give you six whole goldfish crackers for your Fuji apples.

Sally
Thanks, Becky!

Becky
Next!

Grace
This is me, I'm next.

Patty
That was a terrible trade.

Young Grace
Becky.

Becky
Ah Young Grace. I have some Fuji apple slices for you.

Young Grace
Fuji! Wow, those are the good ones, right?

Becky
Oh yes, they are the most valuable of the apple slices. That's for darn sure.

Young Grace
Well, all I have is a peanut butter and honey sandwich, gogurt, rocking strawberry punch Capri-Sun.

Becky
That's all well and good Young Grace, but you failed to mention those Doritos I spy.

Young Grace
But those are my Doritos.

Becky
I want those Doritos. And there is no "RF" on them, that means.. They are not reduced fat? (Evil laugh.)

Young Grace
That's kind of an evil laugh.

Becky
It's genetics. Little Sally, what are you doing here?

Sally
I have buyer's remorse. Can I have my Fuji apples back since they are worthless?

Becky
Worthless?! Who told you that? (Nervous chuckle.) Why don't you ...oh look! Johnny is trying to steal your lunchbox, you better go stop him.

Sally
Johnny, no!

Young Grace
The apples are worthless?

Becky
Second graders. You know how they are. I blame recess. Too much recess. Our education system is terrible. I said "apples and oranges" to her yesterday and she got confused. Where were we?

Young Grace
So, I get Fuji apples for my Doritos.

Becky
And it's the big bag. Your mother must love you very much.

Young Grace
It's mostly guilt. I got blamed for something my father did, and she burned dinner.

Becky
Guilt Doritos are the best kind. Let's trade.

Young Grace
Okay.

Becky
Let me tell you, those Fuji Apples are worthless! (Evil Laugh)

Patty
That was the flashaback?

Grace
Yes.

Patty
That was it?

Grace
Yes.

Patty
But.

Grace
I never trusted anyone else again. Ever.

Patty
You trust me, right?

Grace
Sure.

Patty
That seems like….not a great origin story for a main character.

Grace
What do you mean?

Patty
Your mom burnt dinner one time, and then you got tricked out of Doritos and got some apples instead?

Grace
Really shaped who I am.

Patty
Okay, well,

Grace
I stubbed my too once.

Patty
Teacher said there were four things that made a main character. 1) have a compelling backstory that drives who they are, usually tragic.

Grace
Check.

Patty
Sure. 2) have a loyal sidekick. That’s me. Check.

Grace
Should we test the loyalty?

Patty
3) cannot be gravely injured physically or emotionally no matter what happens, and 4) things usually work out for them.

Grace
Well, I didn’t get hit by that bus, so that sort of is both of those, right?

Patty
Sort of, though I think we should throw you out of a fourth story window just to be sure.

Grace
What?

Patty
Just sort of…

Grace
No.

Patty
But…

Grace
Look, if I'm the main character or not, will that change anything?

Patty
It will change how you live your life!

Grace
Maybe we should just all live like we are the main character of our own stories.

Patty
Could you be any more cliche?

Grace
(Phone rings) Hello? Who? (Whispers to Patty) It's Becky Simmons.

Patty
This is not just a coincidence.

Grace
Sure. Really? Huh. Okay, I suppose. (Hangs up.)

Patty
What?

Grace
She wants to meet. She said she has a deal for me.

Patty
Did she say what it was?

Grace
Just that I'll never look at breakfast shakes the same way after she talks to me.

Patty
You have to meet her. Your archnemesis.

Grace
I know. I just have to run home and change real quick.

Patty
Okay, but you should probably cross at the corner.

Grace
(looks both ways) I think I'm good. (Mirroring the beginning she walks and waves over her shoulder.)

Patty
WATCH OUT!

BLACKOUT